retirement was entirely my call. Then I raised the question of allotting my last Test match to Mumbai and he promised to look into the matter. Allotting a Test match to a city based on a request from a player was a rare and touching gesture.

Before speaking to the BCCI president, I had informed my family that I was planning to retire. Sara asked me if I was retiring from all forms of cricket. I realized she was feeling emotional about the decision. It was natural, but she did her best to conceal it. Arjun was in South Africa at the time and I knew that telling him wouldn't be easy. I was aware of just how much my cricket meant to him. Arjun and I used to laugh about retirement and I often joked that the next series would have to be my last as I was getting so old. This time it wasn't a joke.

On the morning of 10 October, I called Arjun in South Africa and asked him to go to a room where he would be alone as I wanted to tell him something very important. I rang him back after a few minutes and told him that the two Tests against the West Indies in November would be my last. There was complete silence at the other end, so much so that I had to ask if he was still on the line. He said he was but he wasn't able to say anything else and actually hung up on me. I knew he was crying. There was a lump in my throat. I was suddenly feeling a sense of emptiness and needed a few minutes to regain my composure. He called me back ten minutes later and chatted away about what he was up to in South Africa, but my retirement was not mentioned again. It was his way of coping with the news.

The decision was made public that afternoon and it was an emotional time for my family. I felt remarkably calm, though, because I was convinced I had made the right call at the right time. Soon after the news broke, Anjali suggested to me that she should go and fetch Sara from school. On the way back, Anjali read Sara the kind messages she had received on her phone, telling her they were indicative of what the world thought about her baba. When Sara got home, she ran up to me and, without saying a word, just hugged me tight. This time I couldn't help getting emotional too. I was a happy father. My children mean the world to me and it touched me to know that they were proud of what I had achieved. I hoped it also meant that they understood why I had had to go away for such long periods when they were growing up.

By now a crowd had started to build outside the house and I was overwhelmed at the outpouring of emotion. I received a huge number of